

Weekly journal digest for 2026-03-16 to 2026-03-22

Summary

COMAP Journal Bot pulled a large candidate pool this cycle and the curated set ends up leaning in three directions: computational approaches to political text and persuasion, digital campaign and platform effects, and broader questions about governance, inequality, and democratic participation. The strongest pieces for immediate opening are the AJPS paper on using large language models for political texts, the Science Advances paper on biased AI writing assistants, and a late Communication Research paper showing how radical right-wing political deepfakes can delegitimize targeted political actors.

Beyond those headliners, this week's packet has a useful mix of election behavior, ranked-choice voting, survey-response measurement, autocratic participation, coalition and protest-voting methods, and a few carefully selected general-science papers on governance over deep time, cross-national mortality inequality, conservation policy evaluation, cooperation on networks, and worker mobility. The full collected set below is much larger than the attached PDF because the broad-science journals were filtered aggressively for COMAP relevance.

- AI and computational social science are unusually prominent this week, especially around LLM-assisted writing and political text analysis.
- The communication set is strongest on electoral interfaces, stereotype effects, and synthetic-media harms.
- Late additions are substantial and worth checking rather than treating as leftovers; several core political science papers entered through catch-up and late-discovery paths.

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Highlights

Focused on New This Week.

Using large language models to analyze political texts through natural language understanding

American Journal of Political Science | 2026-03-19

Why it matters: A strong methods piece for computational political text analysis: it treats LLMs as language-understanding tools rather than black-box summarizers, which is directly useful for COMAP-style measurement work.

[Open article](#)

From Buttons to Bots: Exploring the Impact of Enhanced Features in Voting Advice Applications on Desktops and Smartphones

Communication Research | 2026-03-19

Why it matters: Worth opening for the platform-design angle: it links interface features and device context to how people process electoral guidance, with clear implications for digital political communication.

[Open article](#)

The distribution of power and inclusiveness across deep time

Science Advances | 2026-03-20

Why it matters: This is the strongest broad-science keep of the week for governance research, offering a comparative framework for locating polities on a collective-versus-autocratic axis.

[Open article](#)

Collection Snapshot	
Total collected candidates:	139
New This Week candidates:	72
Previous Week Catch-Up candidates:	21

Late Additions candidates:	46
Curated digest below:	8 new, 5 catch-up, 20 late additions
Note:	The full collected set above is before manual relevance filtering, while the attached PDF reflects the curated digest.

Full Curated Digest

New This Week

Science Advances

The distribution of power and inclusiveness across deep time

2026-03-20 | Gary M. Feinman; David Stasavage; David M. Carballo; Sarah B. Barber; Adam Green; Jacob Holland-Lulewicz; Dan Lawrence; Jessica Munson; Linda M. Nicholas; Francesca Fulminante; Sarah Klassen; Keith W. Kintigh; John Douglass

Affiliations: Department of Anthropology and Archaeology, University of Bristol, 43 Woodland Road, Clifton, Bristol BS8 1QU, UK.; Department of Anthropology, Boston University, 675 Commonwealth Ave., Boston, MA 02215, USA.; Department of Anthropology, Northwestern University, 1810 Hinman Ave., Evanston, IL 60208, USA.; Department of Anthropology, The Pennsylvania State University, 210 Welch Building, University Park, PA 16802, USA.; Department of Anthropology, University of Central Florida, 4000 Central Florida Blvd., Orlando, FL 32816, USA.; Department of Anthropology, University of Illinois-Chicago, 1007 W. Harrison St., Chicago, IL 60607, USA.; Department of Anthropology-Sociology, Lycoming College, One College Place, Williamsport, PA 17701, USA.; Department of Archaeology and Department of Environment and Geography, University of York, King's Manor, York YO1 7EP, UK.; Department of Archaeology, Durham University, Dawson Building, South Road, Durham DH1 3LE, UK.; Department of Politics, New York University, 19 West 4th Street, New York, NY 10012, USA.; Negaunee Integrative Research Center, Field Museum of Natural History, 1400 S. DuSable Lake Shore Dr., Chicago, IL 60605, USA.; School of Human Evolution and Social Change, Arizona State University, 1151 S. Forest Ave., Tempe, AZ 85281, USA.; Statistical Research Inc., 3170 E. Fort Lowell Road, Tucson, AZ 85716, USA.; The Center for Collaborative Synthesis in Archaeology, Anthropology Department, University of Colorado, 483 UCB, Boulder, CO 80309, USA.; The Institute for the Study of Ancient Cultures, West Asia and North Africa, University of Chicago, 1155 E. 58th St., Chicago, IL 60637, USA.

DOI: 10.1126/sciadv.aec1426

Link: <https://doi.org/10.1126/sciadv.aec1426>

Abstract: This study presents a global, deep-time comparative analysis of governance, questioning entrenched viewpoints about the origins and evolution of democratic institutions. Drawing on archaeological and textual data from 40 case observations across 31 polities, we develop a quantitative framework to assess governance along a collective-autocratic axis, defined by two key dimensions: concentration of power and citizen inclusiveness. Using bridging arguments and robust proxies, we construct an autocracy index to assess where cases fall on this axis and examine them in relation to population size, hierarchical complexity, geographic region, modes of fiscal financing, bureaucratic structure, ritual practices, and socioeconomic inequality. Neither polity population nor geographic region tightly correlates with the collective-autocratic axis of governance, challenging extant neoevolutionary models. Instead, the strongest associations for autocratic governance are with external financing, patrimonial bureaucracy, spectacular ritual, and high inequality. The study underscores the diversity and persistence of collective governance, offering a scalable methodology for future comparative research and reframing historical narratives.

American Journal of Political Science

Rulers on the road: Itinerant rule in the Holy Roman Empire, AD 919-1519

2026-03-19 | Carl MullerCrepon; Clara NeupertWentz; Andrej Kokkonen; Jrgen Mller

Affiliations: Department of Government London School of Economics and Political Science London UK; Department of Political Science Aarhus University Aarhus Denmark; Department of Political Science University of Gothenburg Goteborg Sweden

DOI: 10.1111/ajps.70047

Link: <https://doi.org/10.1111/ajps.70047>

Abstract: Abstract Itinerant rule, rule exercised through traveling, was a common yet insufficiently researched, premodern form of governance. Studying the determinants of ruler itineraries in the Holy Roman Empire, AD 919-1519, we argue that rulers' visits targeted "marginal" elites. Powerful rulers could count on family members and thus targeted unrelated local elites. Weak emperors had to monitor their less loyal relatives and left unrelated nobles unvisited. We reconstruct emperors' itineraries from 72,665 dated and geolocated documents and measure territorial control by their relatives. Exploiting the weakening of imperial power through the Great Interregnum (1250-1273), we find that strong, pre1250 emperors frequented areas controlled by their relatives relatively less. In contrast, family control increased visits post1273. Causal identification rests on the discontinuous reduction of emperors' power through the Great Interregnum and differences in family relations between subsequent emperors. The results show strategic itinerant rule as an important but understudied form of governance.

Using large language models to analyze political texts through natural language understanding

2026-03-19 | Kenneth Benoit; Scott De Marchi; Conor Laver; Michael Laver; Jinshuai Ma

Affiliations: Data Science Institute London School of Economics London UK; Duke University Durham North Carolina USA; Roux Institute Northeastern University Portland Maine USA; School of Social Sciences Singapore Management University Singapore; Wilf Family Department of Politics New York University, New York New York USA

DOI: 10.1111/ajps.70050

Link: <https://doi.org/10.1111/ajps.70050>

Abstract: Abstract Large language models (LLMs) offer scalable alternatives to human experts when analyzing political texts for meaning, using natural language understanding (NLU). Qualitative NLU methods relying on human experts are severely limited by cost and scalability. Statistical textasdata methods are scalable but rely on strong and often unrealistic assumptions. We propose a systematic, scalable, and replicable method that can extend existing qualitative and quantitative approaches by using LLMs to interpret texts meaningfully rather than as mere data. Our ensemble means of LLMgenerated estimates of party positions on six key issue dimensions correlate highly with equivalent mean ratings by country specialists. When applied to coalition policy declarations, LLM estimates align more closely with standard models of government formation than handcoded estimates. We conclude with a discussion of the profound implications of modern LLMs for political text analysis.

You and whose economy? Groupbased retrospection in economic voting

2026-03-19 | Christoffer Hentzer Dausgaard

Affiliations: Department of Political Science University of Copenhagen ster Farimagsgade 5A, 1353 Kbenhavn
Copenhagen Denmark

DOI: 10.1111/ajps.70055

Link: <https://doi.org/10.1111/ajps.70055>

Abstract: Abstract When managing the economy, governments make decisions that influence not only overall growth but also its distribution. How do voters judge incumbents for this? I revisit the idea of groupbased retrospective voting and argue that voters assess the economic performance of their social ingroups relative to the national economy. By sanctioning the incumbent for ingroup performance, voters can incentivize policymaking that better aligns with their interests. I test the theory, first, by estimating the relationship between ingroup performance and incumbent support in panel data. This relationship is comparable in magnitude to sociotropic voting. I further conduct three experiments in Denmark and the United States, randomizing information about the performance of groups defined by geography, age, education, ethnicity, and class. The findings suggest there are limits to sociotropic voting, as voters want their groups to follow or beat the national trend. This has important implications for electoral accountability and party competition.

Communication Research

From Buttons to Bots: Exploring the Impact of Enhanced Features in Voting Advice Applications on Desktops and Smartphones

2026-03-19 | Christine Liebrecht; Naomi Kamoen; Rieke van Lieshout

Affiliations: Radboud University Nijmegen and Tilburg University, The Netherlands; Tilburg University, The Netherlands

DOI: 10.1177/00936502261425713

Link: <https://doi.org/10.1177/00936502261425713>

Abstract: Voters using Voting Advice Applications (VAAs) often struggle with comprehension, leading to satisficing behavior. Conversational Agent VAAs (CAVAAs) aim to improve understanding by allowing users to ask a chatbot comprehension questions. While early research shows positive effects, studies have only compared CAVAAs to basic VAAs, not to enhanced VAAs (VAA+s) with clickable information buttons. Current study compares four versions: a basic VAA, a VAA+, a CAVAA, and a CAVAA+, tested on desktop (Study 1) and smartphone (Study 2). Results show that all three information-rich versions reduce non-directional answers and positively impact political and tool evaluation measures, suggesting that added information, regardless of format, improves response quality and user experience. Interestingly, users request more information in the enhanced web-based VAA+ than via the chatbot. We discuss these and other findings in the paper.

Differential Effects of Counter-Stereotypical Portrayals of Warmth Across Racial Groups: Behavioral and Experimental Evidence

2026-03-18 | Xun Zhu; Youllee Kim; Huai-yu Chen

Affiliations: National Chengchi University, Taipei City, Taiwan; University of Denver, CO, USA; University of Kentucky, Lexington, USA

DOI: 10.1177/00936502261430969

Link: <https://doi.org/10.1177/00936502261430969>

Abstract: This research examines how counter-stereotypical portrayals influence prosocial behavior across racial groups within the context of medical crowdfunding. Drawing on the stereotype content model and expectancy violation theory, we investigate how messages that contradict stereotypes of racial groups perceived as having low warmth violate expectations about these groups and influence campaign donations. Across two studies—an analysis of over 17,000 crowdfunding campaigns (Studies 1a-c) and an online experiment (N = 688; Study 2)—counter-stereotypical portrayals of warmth were associated with higher donations for Asian and White beneficiaries but with lower donations for Black beneficiaries. Expectancy violations mediated these effects, with Black beneficiaries experiencing smaller positive expectancy shifts than other groups. The findings highlight the differential effects of warm-based portrayals across racial groups when used to challenge stereotypes. The study advances theoretical frameworks on stereotypes and expectancy violations while offering practical guidance for more effective and equitable messaging strategies.

Nature Communications

Behavioral shifts mask the success of legislation and outreach for endangered species recovery

2026-03-18 | Victoria J. Bakker; Daniel F. Doak; Alacia Welch; L. Joseph Burnett; Maria C. Porras Pena; Joseph Brandt; Sharon A. Poessel; Steve Kirkland; Rachel Wolstenholme; Daniel Ryan; Mike Stake; Arianna Punzalan; Nacho Vilchis; Melissa A. Braham; Myra E. Finkelstein

DOI: 10.1038/s41467-026-69617-4

Link: <https://doi.org/10.1038/s41467-026-69617-4>

Abstract: Abstract A fundamental challenge in conservation is assessing the efficacy of recovery actions to optimize endangered species management. Considerable recent attention has focused on effective measures to counter the endangerment of avian scavengers, which have declined worldwide, primarily due to poisoning. One iconic example is efforts to recover the critically endangered California condor (*Gymnogyps californianus*), whose leading cause of death is poisoning from ingesting lead-based ammunition in carcasses. Despite enormous resources expended in California, USA, including implementation of public outreach campaigns and two legislative bans on lead ammunition, lead-related mortality of condors has increased. Here we show that two types of behavioral shifts explain the observed increases in condor lead exposure: wilder foraging and ranging by condors and increased shooting of wild pigs (*Sus scrofa*) by humans. After accounting for these trends, we show that both lead ammunition bans and public outreach efforts have significantly reduced condor blood lead levels in California, lowering mortality. Our analyses uncover a dynamic in which changing ecological conditions mask the true efficacy of legislation and outreach. Given rapid global change, such dynamics are likely operating in many settings, underscoring the importance of comprehensive evaluations of recovery actions, which can be obscured by shifting behaviors and threats.

Decomposition of cross-country socioeconomic inequality in mortality by 288 causes of death and 84 risk factors from 1990 to 2021

2026-03-18 | Dong Peng; Rongbin Xu; Simon Hales; Lidia Morawska; Gongbo Chen; Zhengyu Yang; Yiwen Zhang; Michael J. Abramson; Shanshan Li; Yuming Guo

DOI: 10.1038/s41467-026-70877-3

Link: <https://doi.org/10.1038/s41467-026-70877-3>

Abstract: Global cross-country socioeconomic inequalities in all-cause age-standardized mortality (SIAM) have persisted over decades, but major contributing causes and risk factors remain unclear. Here, we quantified contributions of 288 causes and 84 risk factors to SIAM using the Global Burden of Disease Study 2021 (GBD 2021). From 1990 to 2021, communicable, maternal, neonatal, and nutritional diseases' contribution fell from 81.2% to 56.6%, while non-communicable diseases' contribution from 13.2% to 27.8%. The top five causes of death contributing to SIAM in 2021 were COVID-19 (17.9%), stroke (9.4%), tuberculosis (7.3%), lower respiratory infections (7.0%), and diarrheal diseases (5.5%). The top five risk factors contributing to SIAM in 2021 were household air pollution from solid fuels (17.2%), high systolic blood pressure (9.9%), unsafe sex (4.6%), high fasting plasma glucose (4.4%), and unsafe water sources (4.2%). Overall, this study provides policymakers with data to promote global health equity by targeting key causes and risk factors contributing to cross-country mortality inequality.

Previous Week Catch-Up

Science Advances

Biased AI writing assistants shift users' attitudes on societal issues

2026-03-13 | Sterling Williams-Ceci; Maurice Jakesch; Advait Bhat; Kowe Kadoma; Lior Zalmanson; Mor Naaman

Affiliations: Collier School of Management, Tel Aviv University, Tel Aviv, Israel.; Cornell Tech, New York, NY, USA.; Department of Computer Science, Bauhaus University, Weimar, Germany.; Department of Information Science, Cornell University, Ithaca, NY, USA.; Paul G. Allen School of Computer Science and Engineering, University of Washington, Seattle, WA, USA.

DOI: 10.1126/sciadv.adw5578

Link: <https://doi.org/10.1126/sciadv.adw5578>

Abstract: Artificial intelligence (AI) writing assistants powered by large language models (LLMs) are increasingly used to make autocomplete suggestions to people as they write text. Can these AI writing assistants affect people's attitudes in this process? In two large-scale preregiste...

Controlling noisy herds: Temporal network restructuring improves control of indecisive collectives

2026-03-13 | Tuhin Chakraborty; Saad Bhamla

Affiliations: Georgia Institute of Technology, Atlanta, GA, USA.

DOI: 10.1126/sciadv.adx6791

Link: <https://doi.org/10.1126/sciadv.adx6791>

Abstract: Controlling stochastic temporal networks remains an open challenge in control theory. While predictable temporal networks with known future dynamics enhance controllability, real-world networks often exhibit stochasticity and unpredictability, making control harder. Here, we i...

American Journal of Political Science

Encouraging crossover voting in the 2024 presidential primary

2026-03-11 | Hayley M. Cohen; Daniel B. Markovits

Affiliations: Department of Political Science Columbia University New York USA; Department of Political Science University of Houston Texas USA

DOI: 10.1111/ajps.70052

Link: <https://doi.org/10.1111/ajps.70052>

Abstract: Abstract Will voters participate in the primary of a party they oppose to prevent the nomination of a candidate they fear? Partnering with a political action committee, we conduct a firstofitskind, large, preregistered field experiment (N = 83,902) in the leadup to the 2024 R...

American Political Science Review

Exiting Russia

2026-03-11 | RACHEL L. WELLHAUSEN; BOLIANG ZHU

Affiliations: Pennsylvania State University; University of Texas at Austin

DOI: 10.1017/s000305542610152x

Link: <https://doi.org/10.1017/s000305542610152x>

Abstract: As of February 24, 2022, over forty thousand foreign-invested firms operated in Russia, a host state that initiated an interstate war-an exceptional shock in the modern era of economic globalization. Using company registration data, we document that after 18 months of war, 33....

Political Analysis

Inference at the Data's Edge: Gaussian Processes for Estimation and Inference in the Face of Extrapolation Uncertainty

2026-03-10 | Soonhong Cho; Doeun Kim; Chad Hazlett

Affiliations: UCLA

DOI: 10.1017/pan.2026.10032

Link: <https://doi.org/10.1017/pan.2026.10032>

Abstract: Abstract Many inferential tasks involve fitting models to observed data and predicting outcomes at new covariate values, requiring interpolation or extrapolation. Conventional methods select a single best-fitting model, discarding fits that were similarly plausible in-sample b...

Late Additions

American Journal of Political Science

Date	Late additions	Link
2026-03-07	Longrun confidence: Estimating uncertainty when using longrun multipliers Mark David Nieman; David A. M. Peterson 10.1111/ajps.70053	Open
2026-03-05	Politics transformed? Electoral competition under ranked choice voting Peter Buisseret; Carlo Prato 10.1111/ajps.70040	Open
2026-03-05	The declarations of independents: Openended survey responses and the nature of nonidentification Maxwell B. Allamong; Benjamin Beutel; Jongwoo Jeong; Paul M. Kellstedt 10.1111/ajps.70048	Open
2026-03-04	Mitigating policy uncertainty: What financial markets reveal about firmlevel lobbying Kristy Buzard; Nathan Canen; Sebastian Saiegh 10.1111/ajps.70043	Open
2026-03-04	The economic foundations of powersharing: Evidence from Africa Yannick I. Pengl; Philip Roessler 10.1111/ajps.70041	Open
2026-02-25	Latinos mobilizing beyond threats: The role of fear and hope in issue activism Vanessa Cruz Nichols 10.1111/ajps.70037	Open
2026-02-25	Perversity, futility, complicity: Should democrats participate in autocratic elections? Zoltan Miklosi 10.1111/ajps.70049	Open

American Political Science Review

Date	Late additions	Link
2026-03-06	Reconfiguring the Global Color Line: The Paradoxical Discourse of Race in Zou Rong's <i>Revolutionary Army</i> YUANXIN WANG 10.1017/s0003055426101464	Open
2026-03-03	Initiate and Elevate! How Political Parties Can Set an Agenda DANIEL SANDVEJ ERIKSEN 10.1017/s0003055426101506	Open
2026-03-03	Partisan Expressive Responding: Lessons from Two Decades of Research MATTHEW H. GRAHAM 10.1017/s0003055426101452	Open
2026-03-03	Scrutiny and Recall: Rousseau on Controlling the Executive ARTHUR GHINS 10.1017/s0003055426101488	Open
2026-03-02	The Cornered Mouse: Sanctioned Elites and Authoritarian Realignment in the Japanese Legislature, 1936-1942 MAKOTO FUKUMOTO 10.1017/s0003055426101440	Open
2026-02-24	When the Church Votes Left: How Progressive Bishops Supported the Workers' Party in Brazil GUADALUPE TUNON 10.1017/s0003055426101427	Open

Political Analysis

Date	Late additions	Link
2026-03-06	A Multilevel Model for Coalition Governments: Uncovering Party-Level Dependencies Within and Between Governments Benjamin Rosche 10.1017/pan.2026.10039	Open
2026-02-25	A Dynamic Discrete Choice Approach to Attitude Stability and Constraint Alecia Nepaul; Steven Stern 10.1017/pan.2026.10034	Open
2026-02-25	Accounting for Protest Voting in the U.S. Congress Anthony Fowler; Jeffrey B. Lewis 10.1017/pan.2026.10037	Open
2026-02-25	Refining Gamson: The Isometric Log-Ratio Transformation and Portfolio Proportionality in Multiparty Governments Lanny W. Martin; Georg Vanberg 10.1017/pan.2026.10036	Open

Science Advances

Date	Late additions	Link
2026-03-06	Public goods games on any population structure Chaoqian Wang; Qi Su 10.1126/sciadv.aeb1263	Open

Date	Late additions	Link
2026-03-06	Trapped in declining occupations: Barriers to worker mobility in a changing economy Xi Song; Jennie E. Brand; Sukie Xiuqi Yang; Michael Lachanski 10.1126/sciadv.adx3471	Open

Communication Research

Date	Late additions	Link
2026-03-04	Radical Right-Wing Political Deepfakes Can Successfully Delegitimize Targeted Political Actors: Evidence From Three-wave Experiments in the US and The Netherlands Michael Hameleers; Toni G. L. A. van der Meer; Marina Tulin; Tom Dobber 10.1177/00936502261421437	Open

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